

DAY 1: CHIP AWAY AT THAT MORTGAGE

If your mortgage payment is anything like mine, it probably takes up a pretty good portion of your budget. Buying a home is one of—if not *the*—biggest expense we will ever make, and this hefty bank payment leaves little left over at the end of the month for us to afford much of anything else!

But because it is the biggest, it also means we have the opportunity to make an even bigger impact if we lower or eliminate the payment entirely. I know what you're thinking right now—so much for easing into the whole reduce expenses thing, right?

It's true, this expense doesn't always have an immediate reward associated with it, but any opportunity to shorten the lifespan of your loan will literally pay off in the long run. Despite what you (and the banks) might think, your mortgage doesn't have to be a permanent fixture in your budget for the next thirty years. It's time to realize that you have control over those final numbers!

It took me years to start thinking this way. I loved saving money, but was perfectly content to be the responsible young adult who dutifully paid her mortgage every month, with little to no thought of how the bare minimum was affecting the rest of my bottom line. I wanted to give myself that extra cushion for the occasional eating out splurge, and still have enough for a yearly vacation after the rest of my bills were paid. Why sacrifice when you don't necessarily want to...or need to?

My wake-up call happened the first time I really looked at that end-of-year mortgage statement in the mail, and realized how much interest I was paying above and beyond the principal portion of my loan. If nothing else was going to motivate me to be completely debt-free, interest was doing a pretty good job on its own! I promised myself right then and there that I would do whatever steps necessary to pay my mortgage off as quickly as possible.